ISSUE 72
JULY 2026



ESPI Insights

SPACE SECTOR WATCH

Poland and Spain commit nearly €2.7B to IRIS2 and IRIS2-compatible systems



Credit: European Commission

Two EU member states announced major national contributions to the IRIS2 constellation within the same week. **On 21 July 2026, Poland signed an agreement committing €656M to finance six MEO and six LEO satellites operating as a Polish sub-constellation within IRIS2**, along with a satellite gateway in Warsaw connected to the GovNet fibre-optic network. At nearly 10% of IRIS2's estimated total cost of approximately €11B, the commitment is one of the largest national contributions to the programme to date, accompanied by MoUs with SES and Eutelsat including a possible allocation of 2 Gbps of reserved OneWeb capacity.

Days later, **on 29 July, Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez announced a national investment of between €1.6B and €2B under Spain's Multi-orbit Satcom Special Modernisation Programme,** covering the space segment, ground control, and full lifecycle operations of IRIS2-compatible satellites. EU Commissioner Kubilius, who attended the Warsaw signing, framed the deal as models for member state participation.

ESA to establish new civil security and resilience centre in Warsaw



Credit: ESA

ESA and Poland have announced the establishment of a new ESA centre in Warsaw dedicated to civil security and resilience, confirmed at a joint press conference on 13 July 2026 by ESA Director General Josef Aschbacher, Prime Minister Donald Tusk, and Minister of Finance and Economy Andrzej Domański. The centre will contribute to ESA's growing security and resilience activities and operate in complementarity with existing ESA establishments across Europe. Pre-operational activities are expected to begin in 2027, with the centre gradually transitioning to full operation. The announcement follows a Letter of Intent signed between ESA and Poland at the ESA Ministerial Council in Bremen in November 2025, after which a joint ESA-Polish Task Force was established to define the centre's objectives, scope, and implementation framework.

ASI opens IRIDE EO constellation and contracts OHB Italia for PRISMA

On 1 July 2026, ASI launched the operational phase of IRIDE - Italy's PNRR-funded national EO constellation - opening the IRIDE Marketplace to Italian institutional users for satellite tasking, data access, and geospatial services across civil protection, environmental monitoring, and natural resource management applications. The launch marked the formal start of the system's transfer from ESA to ASI as national infrastructure owner, with prime contractors Argotec, e-GEOS, Exprivia, OHB Italia, Planetek, and S&T supporting the first operational phase. Later in the month, on 29 July, **ASI also signed a contract with OHB Italia for the development of PRISMA Second Generation (PSG), a new-generation hyperspectral EO satellite targeting launch by the end of 2031**. PSG is set to improve spatial resolution from 30 metres to below 10 metres and incorporate onboard AI-based processing for the approximately three terabytes of data generated daily. OHB Italia acts as prime contractor, with Thales Alenia Space Italia providing the satellite platform and Leonardo developing the hyperspectral payload under a contract signed in December 2025.

ESA awards ispace-EUROPE €65M contract for MAGPIE, Europe's first lunar rover



Credit: ispace

ESA has awarded ispace-EUROPE a €65M Phase 2 contract on 24 July 2026 for the full execution of MAGPIE — the Mission for Advanced Geophysics and Polar Ice Exploration — marking ESA's first lunar rover mission and a first-of-its-kind small commercial lunar mission for the agency. MAGPIE will explore the Moon's south polar region to characterise volatile deposits, water ice stability, and regolith properties in support of future resource prospecting and sustained human exploration. The mission is scheduled to fly aboard ispace's Mission 4 lunar lander in 2029, itself selected by JAXA in January 2026 under Japan's Space Strategy Fund to develop high-precision landing technology for lunar polar regions. ispace-EUROPE will serve as mission prime, leading mission design, science objectives, rover development, payload integration, and operation.

NATO allies launch HALO satellite constellation initiative

Eight NATO allies — France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Poland, Romania, Spain, and the UK — launched the HALO (Hybrid Alliance Layered Operations in Space) initiative on 7 July 2026 at the NATO Summit Defence Industry Forum in Ankara, committing to develop a networked mega-constellation integrating sovereign, nationally owned military satellites. The initiative targets high-speed secure communications, intelligence collection, and missile tracking, addressing the coverage and resilience limitations of individual national satellite fleets by connecting them into a layered hybrid architecture spanning LEO, MEO, and GEO orbits. Canada also became the 15th member of NATO's STARLIFT initiative, which coordinates access to launch infrastructure across the Alliance for short-notice satellite deployment, while Spain joined NATO's Alliance Persistent Surveillance from Space (APSS) as the 19th participating nation.

US Space Force restructures procurement, and awards multiple contracts

The US Space Force completed its largest acquisition reorganisation since its establishment in 2019, finalising the transition to nine mission-focused Portfolio Acquisition Executives (PAEs), covering: Space Access; Space-Based Sensing and Targeting; Missile Warning and Tracking; Infrastructure; Battle Management, Command, Control, Communications and Intelligence; Satellite Communications and PNT; Advanced Capabilities; Electromagnetic and Cyber; and Space Combat Power. The restructuring transfers approximately 90% of contracting authority directly to individual PAEs, replacing the previous programme-office-centred model with one organised around integrated mission areas.



Credit: satnews

The Space Force also raised the ceiling on the NSSL Phase 3 Lane 1 contract from $5.6B to $17B on 17 July, bringing the combined NSSL Phase 3 total above $30B, with two new providers — Impulse Space and Relativity Federal — added to the Lane 1 vendor pool, bringing the total to seven alongside SpaceX, United Launch Alliance, Blue Origin, Rocket Lab, and Stoke Space. **The first task order under the expanded ceiling was awarded to SpaceX on 29 July: two NSSL Lane 1 task orders totalling $1.6B for 18 Falcon 9 launches through the end of 2027**, carrying satellites for the Space Based Sensing and Targeting portfolio. **Slingshot Aerospace was also awarded a $69.2M SBIR Phase III contract on 15 July for MENTAT**, an AI-powered mission rehearsal platform modelling realistic spacecraft behaviour. **A separate $40M OTA contract was also awarded to Bellevue-based Pulse Space** to develop laser-based power beaming, inter-satellite optical communications, and space situational awareness technologies.

UK commits £62M to space sector and signs innovation partnership with Florida

The UK government has committed £62M (approx. €74M) in new space sector funding at the Farnborough International Airshow, comprising £42M (approx. €50M) for the third round of the Connectivity in Low Earth Orbit (C-LEO) Programme and £20M (approx. €24M) for broader space innovation projects across industry and academia. At the same event, **the UK Space Agency (UKSA) signed an MoU with Space Florida, establishing a £300,000 (approx. €357,000) joint innovation fund drawn from UKSA's International Bilateral Fund and Space Florida's International Aerospace Innovation Fund**, to move early-stage ideas towards commercial demonstration across space transportation, satellite systems, in-space research, advanced exploration, and in-orbit servicing and manufacturing. A formal joint call for projects will open in Autumn 2026, with selections anticipated in 2027; eligible projects must involve at least one UK-based and one Florida-based entity and demonstrate clear commercialisation potential.

China achieves first orbital booster recovery and announces Long March variant

On 10 July 2026, China became the second nation - and the first to use a net-capture system - to successfully recover an orbital-class rocket booster, with the maiden flight of the Long March 10B from the Hainan Commercial Space Launch Site. CASC confirmed the mission successfully deployed an unspecified satellite into its intended orbit and stated it intends to refly the recovered first stage before the end of 2026. **Following the recovery, CALT also confirmed that the Long March 10C is under active development as the programme's primary commercial workhorse,** featuring an all-methalox architecture across both stages for enhanced payload capacity.



Credit: CASC

Later in the month, **on 23 July, a Long March 3B rocket was launched from Xichang and successfully delivered the Tianlian-2-06 communications relay satellite to geostationary transfer orbit**, despite being struck by lightning approximately 30 seconds after its liftoff.

European Commission proposes five defence projects including a space component

On 3 July 2026, the European Commission proposed five new large-scale projects under the European Defence Industry Programme (EDIP), designated as European Defence Projects of Common Interest (EDPCIs), to help EU member states jointly develop key military capabilities. The five projects cover drones and counter-drone systems, maritime and seabed defence, space, air and missile defence, and security along the EU's eastern flank. The space project, described by Commissioner Kubilius as contributing to a "European Air, Maritime and Space Shield", is designed to strengthen space-based defence capabilities across participating member states. The proposal is now with the Council, which must formally adopt a list of identified EDPCIs before they become eligible for EDIP funding. The five projects together represent a combined funding ambition of approximately €190B by 2036.

IN OTHER NEWS

ASI President Teodoro Valente passes away

The Italian Space Agency (ASI) announced the passing of its President, Professor Teodoro Valente, on 16 July 2026, who was appointed in 2023. Vice-President Professor Elda Turco Bulgherini has assumed the presidency to ensure operational continuity.

Serbia and Mauritius sign Artemis Accords

Serbia signed the Artemis Accords on 16 July 2026, and Mauritius followed the next day, becoming respectively the 69th and 70th signatory and seventh African country to join the framework.

Two new Galileo satellites enter service after Ariane 6 launch

SAT 33 and SAT 34, launched in December 2025 aboard Ariane 6, officially entered service on 23 July 2026 following payload commissioning and security accreditation, bringing the number of First Generation Galileo satellites still to be launched to four, with the next pair planned for the end of 2026.

The Netherlands establishes dedicated Space Command

The Netherlands formally established a dedicated Space Command on 30 June 2026 under its Air and Space Force Command (CLRS), one year after adding "space" to the service's name.

ESA opens call to repurpose Europe’s Lunar Gateway module

ESA issued an invitation to tender on 27 July 2026 for studies examining the feasibility of repurposing Lunar Link, the communications element of its ESPRIT Gateway contribution, built by Thales Alenia Space.

FCC approves upper 160 MHz C-band auction

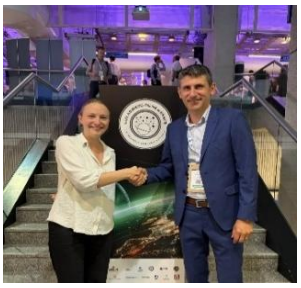
On 22 July 2026, the FCC voted to clear 160 MHz of upper C-band spectrum (3.98–4.14 GHz) for a new 5G auction to be held by July 2027, requiring SES, Eutelsat, and Telesat to relocate incumbent satellite operations by 30 December 2030.

Planet Labs and Isar Aerospace partner to launch German-built Pelican satellite

On 2 July 2026, Planet Labs Germany and Isar Aerospace have partnered to launch Planet Pelican satellites aboard Isar Aerospace's Spectrum launch vehicle, with additional launches planned. Under the launch agreement, the mission is scheduled for no earlier than late 2026 from Isar Aerospace's launch complex at Andøya Space in Norway, with the satellite being assembled in Planet's upcoming Berlin manufacturing facility. The Pelican satellite, with a mass of around 200 kg, will be assembled at Planet's upcoming Berlin manufacturing facility.

Ariane 6 secures fairing supply and explores direct-to-GEO rideshare service

On 8 July 2026, ArianeGroup has signed a contract with Swiss-based Beyond Gravity for the supply of 27 payload fairings covering flight models 16 to 42 of the Ariane 6 launcher, with deliveries beginning at the end of 2026. Beyond Gravity will produce 20 long and seven short payload fairings to support Ariane 6's planned launch cadence of nine to ten missions per year. In the same month, **Arianespace - the commercial arm responsible for marketing and operating Ariane 6 missions - has signed an MoU with French company Infinite Orbits to study the launch capabilities required for a future direct-to-GEO rideshare service**. The collaboration focuses on deploying inspection and life-extension missions to geostationary satellites.



Credit: Arianespace

ICEYE expands in Europe, grows constellation, and launches new disaster services

ICEYE launched four Gen4 SAR satellites aboard SpaceX's Transporter-17 rideshare mission on 7 July 2026, bringing its total constellation to 76 satellites in orbit, including the Finnish Defence Forces' third dedicated satellite, deployed via Exolaunch. In the same week, the company opened two new European entities: **a German subsidiary in Berlin and Munich on 8 July, with Philipp Herkelmann appointed as country CEO** to lead satellite component manufacturing, an AI and intelligence centre, and the Rheinmetall ICEYE Space Solutions (RISS) joint venture; and, the following day, **a centre of excellence in Lisbon, led by Rui Costa**, to support the Portuguese Air Force's four-satellite constellation and develop software, systems integration, and end-to-end intelligence capabilities.

On the commercial side, **ICEYE extended its wildfire intelligence solution to Canada** and **signed a partnership with South Korean satellite operator KT SAT** to deliver SAR-based flood monitoring to government agencies and commercial customers ahead of South Korea's annual monsoon season.

The Exploration Company opens a Houston lab and establishes a US entity

On 8 July 2026, **The Exploration Company (TEC) established TEC Federal, a dedicated US entity to enable participation in US government programmes and contracts, alongside a Rapid Innovation Lab in Houston, Texas**, near NASA Johnson Space Center. The Houston lab features a full-scale mockup of the future Nyx cargo capsule and is intended to support rapid prototyping and interface development in close collaboration with NASA personnel and astronauts. This marks TEC's first permanent US operational presence, complementing existing sites across Europe and the UAE.



Credit: The Exploration Company

Starlab secures SES communications deal and signs new research reservations



Credit: SES

Starlab Space signed an agreement with SES Space & Defence on 27 July 2026 for the provision of always-on LEO relay communications via SES's O3b mPOWER MEO constellation, developing a communications architecture to deliver continuous, low-latency connectivity for station operators, researchers, and crew throughout the station's lifecycle via SES Space & Defence's LEO Relay Services.

The month also saw Starlab add three research reservations: **South Korean biopharma company Space LiinTech reserved payload capacity on 8 July** for AI-driven pharmaceutical and life sciences research in microgravity; **Space Scotland reserved payload access on 14 July** to support Scottish companies, universities, and research organisations across healthcare, materials science, and advanced manufacturing; and the **Center for Space and Aviation Switzerland and Liechtenstein (CSA) reserved space on 21 July** for biotechnology, pharmaceutical, and precision electronics research.

ispace expands lunar infrastructure with Starship, H3 contracts and JSAT MoU

On 8 July 2026, ispace purchased 500 kg of payload capacity on a SpaceX Starship lunar lander and started development of a Mobile Cargo System, a rover designed to carry customer payloads from the Starship lander up to a few kilometres away, targeting a flight no earlier than 2030 and complementing ispace's existing lunar transportation services using its ULTRA landers. Later in the month, **ispace and Japanese company SKY Perfect JSAT signed an MoU to study the use of SKY Perfect JSAT's commercial near-Earth tracking network** for communications between JSAT Space Line ground stations and the ULTRA lander during its Mission 3 scheduled for 2028. **On 29 July, ispace also signed a contract with Mitsubishi Heavy Industries (MHI) for launch and transportation services for Mission 3 ULTRA aboard MHI's H3 rocket**.

Skyroot Aerospace completes India’s first private orbital launch with Vikram-1



Credit: Skyroot Aerospace

Indian launch startup Skyroot Aerospace has successfully completed the first private orbital launch from India on 18 July 2026, placing payloads into orbit aboard its Vikram-1 rocket from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota. The mission, named Aagaman, carried two CubeSats - one built by Skyroot and one by Indian startup Grahaa Space - alongside hosted payloads from deployment technology company Dcubed and space services firm Cosmoserve Space.

Intel develops Starfire radiation-hardened chip for satellite onboard AI processing



Credit: Intel Corp.

Intel has developed Starfire, a satellite system-on-chip (SoC) designed for onboard data processing and AI workloads in space. The chip adapts a commercial SoC architecture for the space environment, incorporating radiation mitigation features and a design lifespan of over ten years. Intel says the chip targets the growing small satellite market as well as broader government and commercial spacecraft applications, with availability to customers expected by the end of 2026 pending completion of its radiation qualification.

SpaceX launches Falcon 9 twice, tests Starship and expands Starlink operations

On 7 July 2026, SpaceX launched 81 payloads aboard Falcon 9 on the Transporter-17 rideshare mission from Vandenberg Space Force Base, with Exolaunch deploying 49 customer satellites including four for ICEYE. Among the payloads were French company Unseenlabs' second-generation SAR constellation, two British Open Cosmos satellites - including the first satellites of a Balearic Islands EO constellation and a planned Greek constellation - the inaugural Nova satellite from Apex Space, the first operational satellites of the FireSat wildfire monitoring constellation built by Muon Space for the Earth Fire Alliance, and City Lab's BOHR satellite. **More than 280 components and payloads across the mission were supplied by four South African companies**: CubeSpace, NewSpace Systems, Simera Sense, and Dragonfly Aerospace.



Credit: SpaceX

In the same week, **SpaceX filed with the FCC for authorisation to launch 100,000 Gen3 Starlink satellites offering multi-gigabit connectivity** - a filing separate from the company's February 2026 request to deploy up to one million satellites as orbital data centres. While, on 14 July, **Indigo Partners - whose portfolio includes Frontier, Wizz Air, Volaris, JetSMART, and Cebu Pacific - signed a Starlink in-flight connectivity agreement covering more than 1,000 aircraft**, with Frontier's first equipped aircraft targeted for early 2027. Later in the month, on 21 July, **Falcon 9 launched Northrop Grumman's Mission Robotic Vehicle to GEO,** where it will deploy propulsion modules onto existing satellites to extend their operational lives by at least six years. Three days later, **Starship Flight 13 lifted off from Starbase, Texas**, deploying 20 Starlink V3 satellites from its payload bay for the first time and completing the first fully soft splashdown in the programme's history.

Orienspace launches nine satellites on third Gravity-1 sea-based mission

On 22 July 2026, **Chinese launch company Orienspace launched its third Gravity-1 solid rocket from a launch service ship off the coast of Shanghai**, placing nine satellites into orbit. The mission carried six Dongpo satellites for the Huantian constellation - including two optical satellites with onboard AI image processing payloads and four SAR satellites in formation flying configuration - alongside a hyperspectral satellite from Xi'an CAS Xiguang Aerospace Technology Group, a satellite from Spacety, and an ultra-flat disk-shaped satellite developed by the Harbin Institute of Technology and Beijing Taikonlink Technology.



Credit: Orienspace

Amazon LEO partners with South Africa's Herotel to launch satellite internet service

Amazon LEO signed a partnership agreement with Herotel, South Africa's largest fixed internet service provider, on 16 July 2026, to deliver satellite broadband through Herotel's new consumer brand, evry, targeting a commercial launch in 2027. The deal aims to extend connectivity to rural and underserved communities where terrestrial broadband is commercially unviable to deploy, and it comes as several LEO operators compete for access to South Africa's broadband market, with Starlink yet to secure a commercial licence due to the country's local ownership requirements.

IN OTHER NEWS

Univity signs MoU with Telkomsat on VLEO D2D Connectivity

French company Univity signed an MoU with Indonesian company Telkomsat to explore VLEO and D2D satellite connectivity solutions for enterprise and mobility applications for unserved and underserved areas.

Infostellar selects SSC Space for Seiren's FUSION-1 mission

On 7 July 2026, Swedish company SSC Space and Japanese company Infostellar signed a contract to provide ground station services for Seiren's FUSION-1 small satellite mission through SSC Space's newly launched SSC Space Go service.

D-Orbit and ArkEdge Space sign launch services contract

Italian-based company D-Orbit signed a contract with the Japanese company ArkEdge Space to deploy its satellites into Sun-synchronous orbit aboard D-Orbit's ION service across multiple missions between 2027 and 2028.pac

Rivada and Mercantile Space partner for secure connectivity

German company Rivada won a deal with Nepalese company Mercantile Space to deliver secure LEO satellite connectivity for enterprise and government customers across Nepal.

Final Atlas V mission delivers 29 Amazon Leo satellites

On 2 July 2026, a ULA Atlas V lifted off from Cape Canaveral Space Force Station carrying 29 Amazon Leo satellites, marking the last satellite payload mission for the Atlas V rocket. The launch concludes the nine Atlas V missions Amazon purchased from ULA in 2021 for its broadband constellation.

Amazon Leo files for 5,105 satellites in Globalstar spectrum

Amazon has filed with the FCC for authorisation to launch a D2D constellation of up to 5,105 satellites, using spectrum to be acquired in the Globalstar deal.

MDA Space to acquire a majority interest in French Collecte Localisation Satellites

Canadian MDA has entered into an offer to acquire **a 70% interest in the French Earth observation company Collecte Localisation Satellites (CLS).** CLS has been jointly owned since 2020 by a private Belgian investment company CNP (66% shareholder) and the French Space Agency CNES (34% shareholder). After the completion of approx. €567M transaction, CNES would retain an approx. 30% share, while CNP would sell its stake. The acquisition is subject to regulatory approval and is not expected to be finalised until the end of 2026.

Credit: CLS

For MDA space, the acquisition would enable **vertical integration** of its upstream satellite assets with AI-driven analytics, connectivity solutions and proprietary algorithms from CLS. It would also expand MDA's global presence since the customer base of CLS stretches across 150 countries. The announcement comes just weeks after MDA Space signed a definitive agreement to acquire the US based satellite component manufacturer **Blue Canyon Technologies**.

York Space Systems acquires British satcom terminal company All.Space

The US-based space and defence prime **completed the acquisition of British All.Space**, a satellite communications terminal manufacturer for approx. $300M, consisting of $155M in cash and 5.9 million shares of York common stock. As part of the transaction, **the UK company relocated to the US**. The deal's price fell from the **initial April announcement of $355M**. The acquisition enables York to integrate All.Space's multi-link terminal technology into its existing space infrastructure. Following **York's IPO in January**, it has moved to acquire several other companies, including the propulsion manufacturer **Orbion Space** and the space solar technology startup **Solestial**.

Antares closes $370M Series C round for nuclear microreactor deployment



Credit: Antares

US company Antares has raised **$370M in its Series C round** co-led by Paradigm and Caffeinated Capital, with participation from Point72 Ventures, Shine Capital, Industrious Ventures, among others. The company also secured an additional $100M in debt financing. The closing of Series C comes 7 months after the company raised its **Series B in December 2025**. Antares is developing modular and transportable reactors for both Earth and space applications. A few weeks before the latest funding announcement, the company successfully conducted a reactor demonstration under the **US Department of Energy Reactor Pilot Program**. The company is now finalising the reactor design, targeting electricity production in 2027, and deployment on military satellite constellations in 2028.

Chang Guang Satellite Technology raises approx. €614M in equity funding

Chinese remote sensing satellite manufacturer Chang Guang Satellite Technology (CGSTL) has announced **nearly ¥5 billion (approx. €614M) raised in a fresh equity financing** round. The round was led by Changfa Group and Landstone Capital and saw participation from state-owned private equity firms including Shenzhen Capital Group and Orient Asset Management among other investors. The company has launched more than 100 of its Jilin-1 satellites in orbit since its inception in 2014. The funds raised will be used to further increase manufacturing capacity of its Jilin-1 satellites, consolidate its high-resolution data acquisition capabilities, and deepen the development of applications for its remote sensing data across industries.

Voyager Technologies completes acquisition of Astrobotic Technology



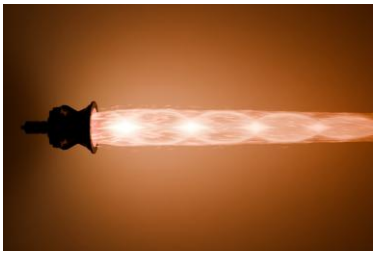
Credit: Voyager Technologies

Voyager Technologies has completed the acquisition of Astrobotic Technology**,** committing up to $300M, with $162M in cash and stock, along with assuming $9M in debt and a potential $129M in earnout payments contingent on performance milestones. For Voyager, the acquisition supports its **strategic lunar initiative** and efforts to deliver foundational lunar infrastructure. The completion of the acquisition from the US companies comes shortly after **Astrobotic secured two NASA contracts** totalling $298M to fly two of its Peregrine lunar landers to the Moon by the end of 2028.

Chinese internet satellite manufacturer Hongqing raises approx. €162M

Chinese satellite manufacturer Hongqing Technology has completed a **"Pre-Series B" funding round**, raising ¥1.3 billion (approx. €162M), co-led by CCB Investment, ICBC Capital, and Jinpu Capital, with participation from Sichuan Development Technology Fund, Bank of China International, CITIC Securities, Yuanyu Capital, and Bofu Fund, among other investors, including municipal and state-linked investment vehicles. The fresh capital will be allocated to scaling manufacturing operations, with a targeted annual production capacity of 100 to 500 satellites, advancing R&D on satellite internet payloads and expanding the company's end-to-end constellation solution offering for domestic and international operators.

Venus Aerospace closes $91M round to advance development of rocket engine



Credit: Venus Aerospace

US propulsion company Venus Aerospace has closed a **$91M Series B round** led by Mercury Fund, with participation from Lockheed Martin Ventures, MESH, PEAK6, Draper Associates, Starboard Star Venture Capital, among others. The firm will use the capital to scale development and production of its Rotating Detonation Rocket Engine (RDRE), transitioning the technology from flight demonstration towards deployable propulsion systems for near-term defence and space applications. The RDRE employs a continuous supersonic detonation wave rotating around the combustion chamber. Venus Aerospace claims a 15% efficiency improvement over conventional rocket engines, alongside reusability. The company also states that the engine can be used for different mission applications, ranging from munitions to space launch and orbital transfer.

SWISSto12 secures $70M to expand satellite integration and manufacturing

Switzerland-based small-GEO satellite manufacturer SWISSto12 has raised **$70M in a Series C funding round** to expand its manufacturing and integration capabilities. To date, the company has secured seven contracts for its HummingSat GEO small-satellite platform, including agreements with operators such as SES and Viasat. It has also expanded its HummingLink payload and antenna solutions into LEO constellation programmes across Europe and the Asia-Pacific region. According to the company, its contract backlog is worth more than $500M. The new funding will help SWISSto12 scale up manufacturing and integration capacity to meet growing demand from commercial and institutional customers.

IN OTHER NEWS

China's LegendSpace raises €25M in a seed round

The Chinese six-month-old startup raised ¥200M (approx. €25M) to develop liquid rocket engines with the help of its AI research platform. Investors of the round include multiple private VC firms, such as Vitalbridge, Shangshi Capital, Crystal Stream Capital and Oriental Fortune Capital.

Flexell Space raises €15M for space solar solutions

South Korean startup Flexell Space raised KRW25 billion (approx. €15 million) in its Series A round. The round included domestic public investors, including Industrial Bank of Korea and the Korea Credit Guarantee Fund, and several private VC firms. The round is supporting the commercialisation process of the company's space solar cell technology.

DeltaVISION secures €10.2M to expand valve production

The Munich-based startup, which builds valves, pumps and fluid control systems for spacecraft, has closed its first funding round of €10.2M. The company, which claims to have been profitable since its inception in 2022, attracted KT Ventures and Valemount Capital as lead investors.

Italian startup ORiS closes €4.5M pre-seed round

Turin-based ORiS, which is developing a power beaming technology that uses lasers to transmit power to satellites, has raised a €4.5M pre-seed round. The round was co-led by Earlybird and Pitchdrive, with participation from Galaxia, Vento and Piemonte Next Fund. The company also secured a €500.000 grant from the Piedmont region's start-up support programme.

Dhruva Space raises €5.6M from Antariksh VC Fund

Indian startup Dhruva Space announced it has secured ₹600M (approx. €5.6M) from the Antariksh VC Fund. It is the first company to receive an investment from India's new ₹16 billion large space-tech fund, established by IN-SPACe and managed by SIDBI VC. The satellite startup will use the funds to expand manufacturing and accelerate infrastructure development.

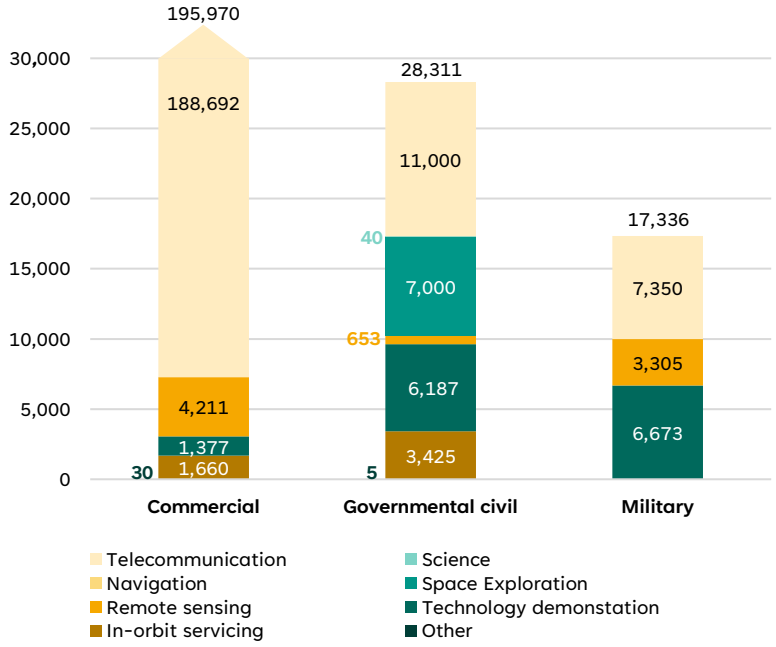
LAUNCHES & PAYLOAD – JULY 2026

Launch provider's region	USA	China	Europe	Russia	India	Japan	Others	Total
Number of launches	15	9	0	2	1	0	0	**27**
Number of spacecraft launched	367	59	0	17	2	0	0	**445**
Mass launched (in kg)	191,621	37,070	0	12,920	5	0	0	**241,616**

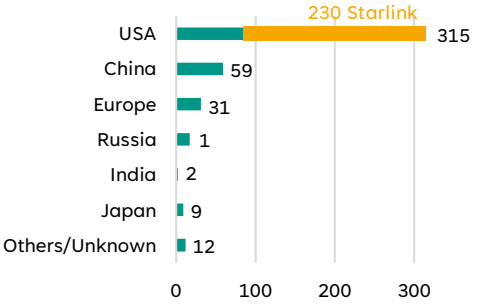
Top launch service providers of the month

1. SpaceX (13)
2. CASC (7)
3. Roscosmos (2)

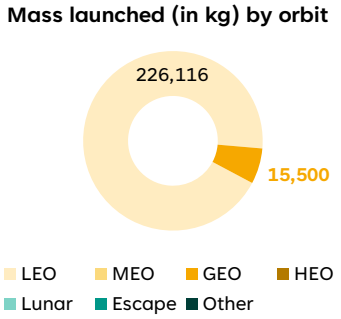
Mass launched (in kg) by market and by mission

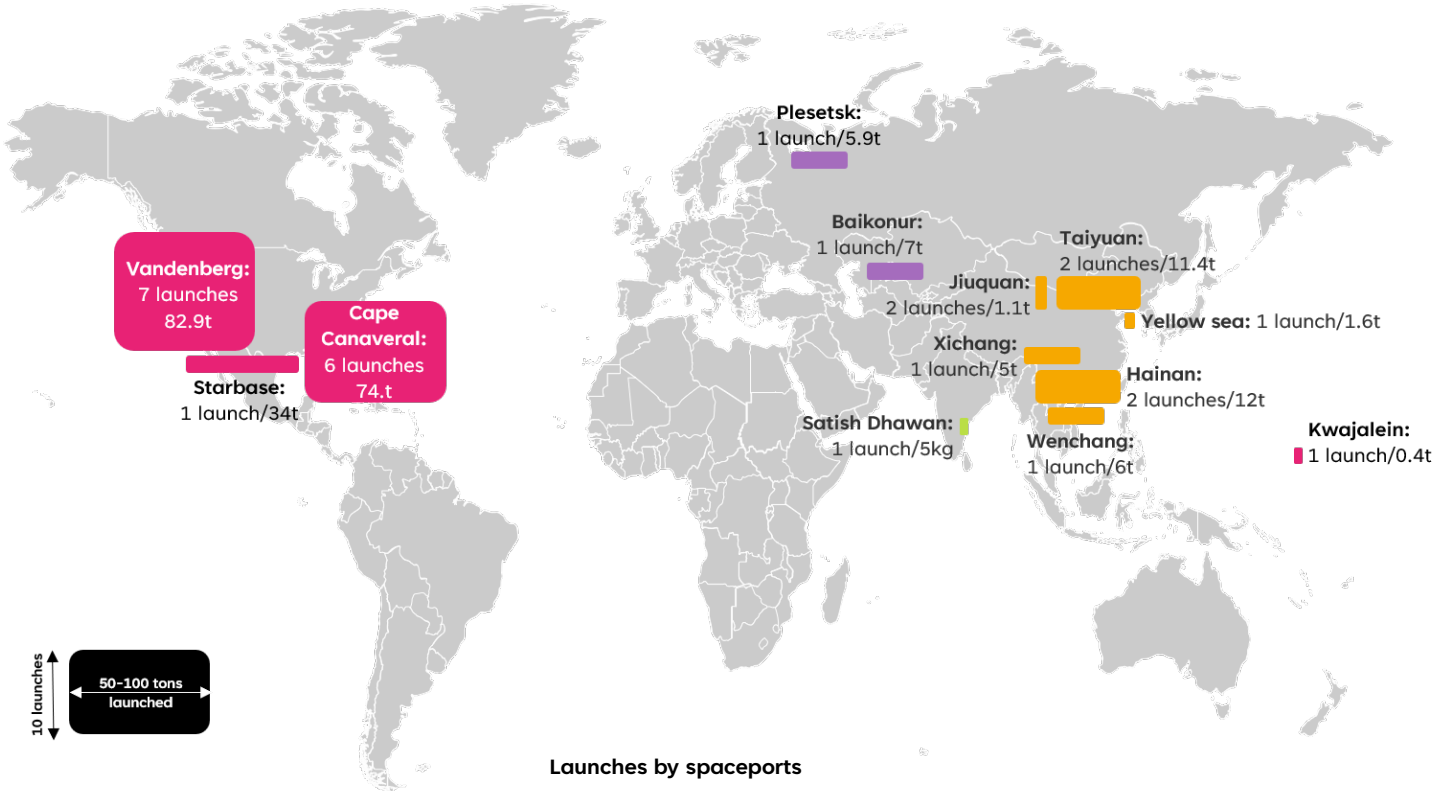


Number of spacecraft launched by payload owner's region



Mass launched (in kg) by orbit





Launches by spaceports

*The data is an estimation from ESPI's internal launches dataset, publicly accessible through the **ESPI Launch Dashboard**.*

ESPI Insights

EDITORIAL TEAM

EDITORIAL MANAGEMENT

Michele d'Emilia

POLICY & PROGRAMMES

Michele d'Emilia

INDUSTRY & BUSINESS

Michele d'Emilia
Fanny Ayat

INVESTMENT & FINANCE

João Falcão Serra
Ieva Kalnina
Virginio Dotto

LAUNCHES & PAYLOADS

Elizaveta Shashkova
Valentin Hoffmann